The Anatomy of Wolves

By Danielle Wood

ROSIE: **(Pg 111+)** ***The wolf has legs . . .*** *A*nd these were the parts of him that I saw first. I was standing at the bottom of a backstage staircase and he was at the top, his shins sticking out from beneath a taffeta ballgown in an alarming shade of yellow.

HIM: You must be Reporter Rosie.

ROSIE: Is now a good time?

HIM: Rehearsals start again at two. We could do it over lunch, if you like.

ROSIE: *(flirtatiously)* Only if you leave that dress on. And promise not to say "eclectic" [or] I shall be forced to write evil things about your play. *(waving her notebook) (to audience)* At least, I think that is what we said. I was 22, just beginning at the metropolitan daily newspaper and almost certainly in love.

INTRODUCTION

In this modern take of Little Red Riding Hood, Rosie doesn't realize she's stepped off the safe path. She thinks she's just interviewing some quirky actor in a yellow ballgown, trading jokes and enjoying the kind of banter that feels fun and harmless. But little by little, it becomes clear he is anything but harmless. Rosie's getting cozy with a wolf, the kind who hides in charm and costume instead of fur.

It's easy to miss the danger when the wolf smiles, walks on two legs, and makes you feel chosen.

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4NG Fanatics

ROSIE: I walked with him to the theatre and, at the stage door, when we pulled ourselves apart: 'Good luck,' I said just before I remembered this was not the thing to say at all. Whistling backstage, the naming of the Scottish play, the wishing of good luck: all these things are forbidden in the theatre. Instead of 'good luck', one might say 'break a leg.' But there is another alternative to 'good luck'; one that I have recently learned, and one that would — in hindsight at least — have been eerily apt. ***In bocca al lupo***. *Into the mouth of the wolf* -- an Italian phrase that is meant to bestow luck and instill courage.

Only weeks later, we moved in together, renting a small flat behind a pizza shop.

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The wolf has claws. But I didn't see them for quite a long time. There were too many diversions. . . Often, he did the housework as Jesus, wrapped in a white sheet and singing Sunday school hymns over the top of the howling vacuum cleaner. Once, when I was sick with a cold, he borrowed a nurse's outfit from the theatre's costume shop, and ministered to me in a lispy falsetto until I laughed myself better. For the winter solstice we took blankets and candles to the local cemetery and read vampire stories to each other while the concrete cold of the graves seeped into our bones. More and more often, though, we stayed home at night on the weekends and watched old movies. . . We folded into each other like a pair of socks.

I remember the night of his birthday in colors. There was the beetle-green glitter eyelids of Cleopatra -- one of the girls from the theatre, and the peacock silk shirt of a guy salty-white hair. There was the red of my tartan skirt and the swirls and layers of bright liquor that were poured into shot glasses as we competed to drink more. The music was loud and silly, but with an irresistible

4N6 Fanatics

dance beat. I was heady, giggly, and then, suddenly, alone.

'Oh yeah,' said the Cleopatra girl. 'He went home.'

Cross and confused, I walked the few blocks to our flat without a coat, the cold of the night bringing a kind of sobriety. When I got there, he was sitting in the dark. The light I switched on was bright and I saw that he had been crying. The rims of his eyes were reddened. His irises a malignant green, his lips and cheeks pale and slack. But I was not sensible enough to be afraid. He shouted and accused.

HIM: Why didn't you just *sleep with* him?

ROSIE: Who? You're not making any sense! *(to audience)*

He stood over me, but I did not back down. Nor did I see it coming. It was too far beyond my experience, too far outside my expectations. His fist felt huge against my small face.

On the couch, I couldn't sleep. In our bed, he could. When the morning came, on his way out the door, he kissed my cheek softly. He came home with treats, and to begin with I was like a child who would not be

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enticed. I shook my head to chocolates in the shape of ladybirds wrapped in shiny red foil and to a tiny iridescent fish in a plastic bag of water. I cried and said no to striped socks with toes in them and to a jar full of tiny rubber dinosaurs that were purple, orange and yellow.

But I caved in when he ran me a bath and filled it with bubbles. I let him put a cotton pad soaked in witch-hazel over my bruised and swollen eye, and read to me -- doing all the voices and accents, too -- which made me cry. The tears were a drug whose effect felt like love.

The morning after the night on which he hit me for the second time, he looked at my face and then he put his head in my lap and cried. I stroked and soothed him, pushing my fingers into his beautiful hair. The grazed skin on the inside of my mouth felt like raw steak. I could still taste blood.

I had arrived late home from work to find the flat in darkness. He was crouched in the corner whimpering

HIM: I thought you'd left me.

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ROSIE: I crouched down beside him, held out the back of my hand as if to a wounded dog. *(to him)* Hey, I was just at work. I'm sorry, I should have called.

HIM: *(slightly louder)* You'll leave me. One of these days you'll leave me, I know you will.

ROSIE: I won't. I won't. I won't ever leave you.

HIM: *(snarling)* Don't LIE! *(strikes her with his fist)*

ROSIE: Later that week, my bruises under the cover of the older women's makeup, we sat at his parents' table. We all said amen into our laps and then the house resumed a silence that didn't feel safe. For all of the time it had taken her to make the gravy, his mother had said nothing. Now she pushed some food onto her fork and brought it halfway to her mouth, then put it down again as if it disgusted her. She looked up at her son with her big and green and sad eyes.

MOTHER: You did do that to her, didn't you?

HIM: Do what?

MOTHER: I know what it looks like when a man hits a woman. I know exactly what it looks like. And it looks like that. *(beat)* I can't. I just can't!

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ROSIE: . . . she said standing up at the table and taking away his still-full plate and mine. She tipped our meat and vegetables into the pedal bin and let the lid fall. She was standing over it, sob-breathing and gulping, as we left the house. In the dark of the driveway, I felt ashamed.

The wolf has teeth. It was true that his top incisors sloped inward a little, making his canines appear quite prominent; but it was not these that bit. It was the clean and white-painted right angle of the edge of our bedroom door. I hammered into it fast, a dervish, whirling. My brow-bone fractured on impact. Skin split and out poured unexpectedly dark blood. It streaked down the white paint as I slid to the floor.

I had gone home, to my parents' house, for a weekend. but not without fear of what I would find when I returned. This time, it was tequila instead of gin. And this time, my hands were up, quickly, in a flimsy block between my face and his chest. I felt adrenalin gush to my hands and feet as he grabbed me, tightly, and held me by both wrists.

4N6 Fanatics

HIM: Why did you even bother to come back? You love them more than you've ever loved me.

ROSIE: He pulled me towards him and then pushed. I left his grip in a fast, hard spin, and collected the door with my face.

The wound would heal and, over time, fade into a pale crescent scar. But now it was an ugly gash of puckered skin and knotted twine marking the midpoint of eye sockets stained magenta and purple. My forehead was swollen and misshapen. The fine crack revealed by the X-ray was concealed beneath my swollen forehead, but in the mirror I could see the unmissable sign of ownership. A brand.

I was not allowed to leave the hospital until I had seen the domestic violence counselor.

COUNSELOR: He'll bash you again.

ROSIE: I argued that I knew how to avoid it now. If I could just keep my mouth shut at the right moment. If I didn't provoke him when he'd been drinking. She looked at me wearily, and I began to hear myself. After I had been

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silent for a time, she looked at her watch and said that I could go.

COUNSELOR: You'll have to have someone pick you up? Must be someone.

ROSIE: There was only one person. But instead, I took a taxi to the home of a friend who wouldn't scold. In the late morning, washed, and dressed in borrowed clothes, I went back to the apartment. He was sleeping. I sat beside him for a while, on the edge of our bed, watching dream-tremors flit through the muscles under the skin of his face.

The wolf has a heart. And there were times, during the year of my lesson in wolf anatomy, when I was close enough to see it. Just a glimpse of it, beating red and slick inside the dark fur.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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